

People

Personas

Meet Vasanth

- Age 21
- Studies Law at St. Andrews
- Enjoys playing volleyball and board games
- Loves to cook for his friends
- Extroverted and reliable

The organiser.

Early on in our DRP project, we created Vasanth, and used his story to guide BeThere's development. Vasanth was intended to be an embodiment of the heart of a friend group. Popular and outgoing, his hobbies are deeply social, and he lives for his friends. He is selfless and responsible, which naturally leads him to take on the role of organiser.

However, like many other university students, he still struggles with loneliness.

He tries tirelessly to see his friends more but the burden and pressure of being the initiator is leading him to feel frustrated and hopeless. Poor communication, uncertain replies, and a feeling of being the only one brave enough to initiate have all fuelled Vasanth's struggle. What was once a feeling of joy at the thought of making new plans, is now an empty dread at the reality of chasing responses.

Vasanth's experiences resonated strongly with us, and drove us to seek the root causes of failed meetups and poor communication.



Meet Milly

- Age 19
- Studies English Literature at St. Andrews
- Likes to play cello and read
- Recently joined her university's netball society and Vasanth's friend group
- Shy and introverted

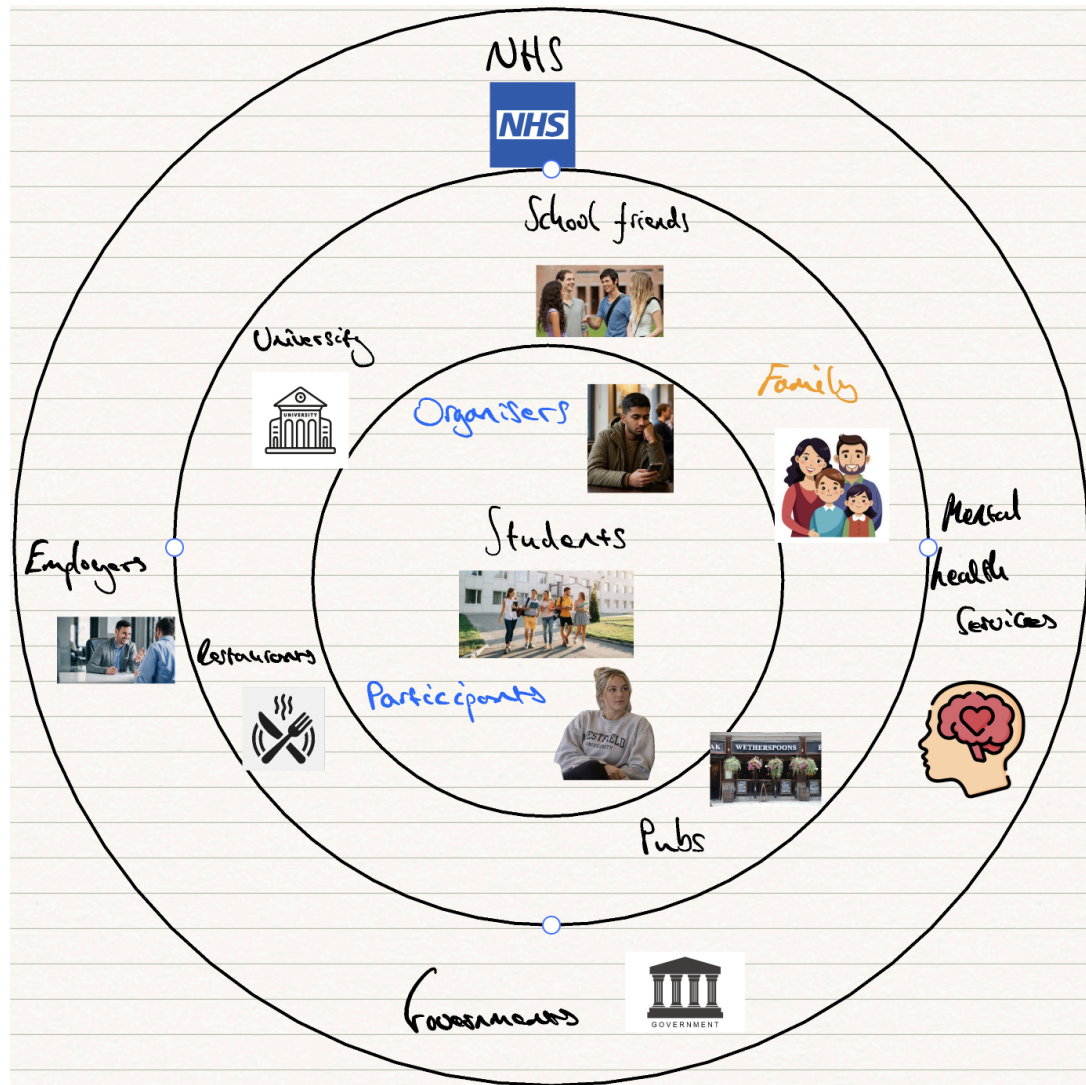
The passive participant

Appreciating that every failed meetup has two sides to it, we realised the necessity of having a second persona, so we proposed Milly, the antithesis of Vasanth. She is very introverted, and symbolises the quiet participants of a friend group who prefer tagging along to organising their own events.

We did not mean Milly to be antisocial. For this reason, we chose Milly to be a new member of Vasanth's friend group, explaining her shyness without giving the impression she didn't want to engage with her new friends. This allowed us to explore the reasons why people give vague 'maybe' replies, without the assumption that these people simply don't want to see their friends, an explanation we rejected.



Stakeholders



Undergraduates are our main stakeholders, but within this group we identified two further categories: organisers and participants. Organisers are people like Vasanth, who make meetup suggestions to their friend groups and carry them all the way through taking on a myriad of responsibilities: working out each friend's schedule, picking times that suit everyone, chasing

hesitant or unresponsive people. On the other side we have participants like Milly, who rarely suggest meetups themselves but take part; from interviewing students, we found these people typically don't like to attend events without someone they know quite well - their attendance is dependent on others going and when they're not sure those friends will go they become non-responsive or reply with a 'maybe'.

Thinking about the wider impacts, if undergraduates spend more time with their friends, those places they meet will benefit, such as pubs and restaurants. We'd also expect to see improvements to larger university communities as the effects of happier, tighter-knit friend groups ripple outwards. We're the most connected generation, and yet we're the loneliest. The NHS is reporting a loneliness crisis, 15-24s spend 70% less time with their friends in-person than two decades ago, and over 25% of lonely young people have sought therapy; if we can make it easier for friends to meetup in-person, we can help fix this.

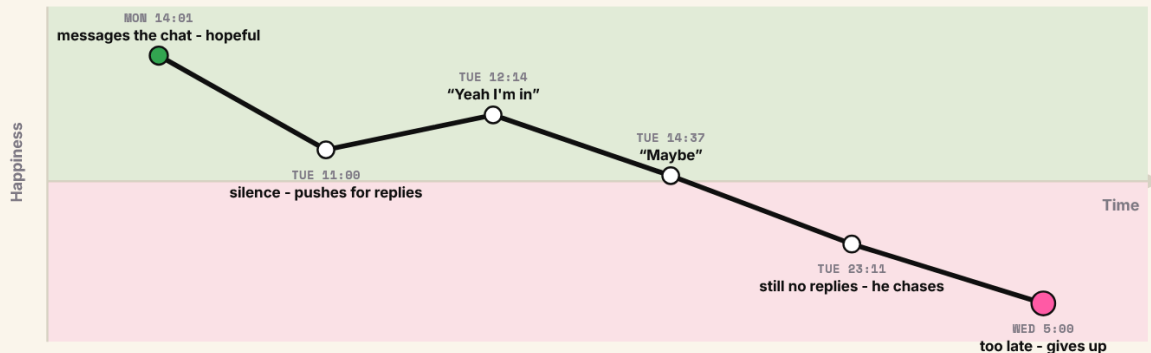
Current State

User Journey Maps

To provide a strong basis for our problem, we constructed a realistic scenario that could be told from two perspectives, those of Vasanth and Milly. We chose a pub quiz as the setting, since this was an event where if Milly turned up without a close friend there, there was high potential for it to be awkward and leave Milly feeling alienated from her new friends. These high social stakes provided the perfect background to map out the reasons why people respond with 'maybe'.

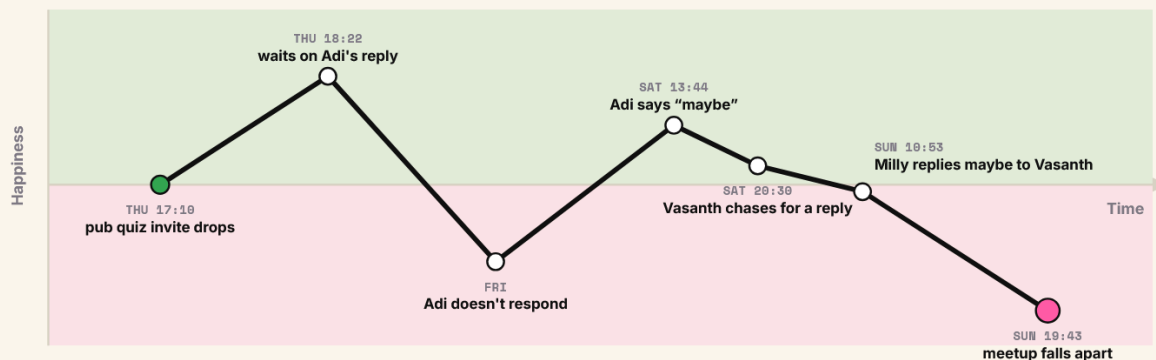
From Vasanth's perspective, it's an event that requires an explicit organiser to choose a location and reserve a table for example.

Vasanth's pub quiz last week, mapped as he felt it



From Milly's perspective, it's a daunting social event that she would be much more comfortable attending if she has a close friend there.

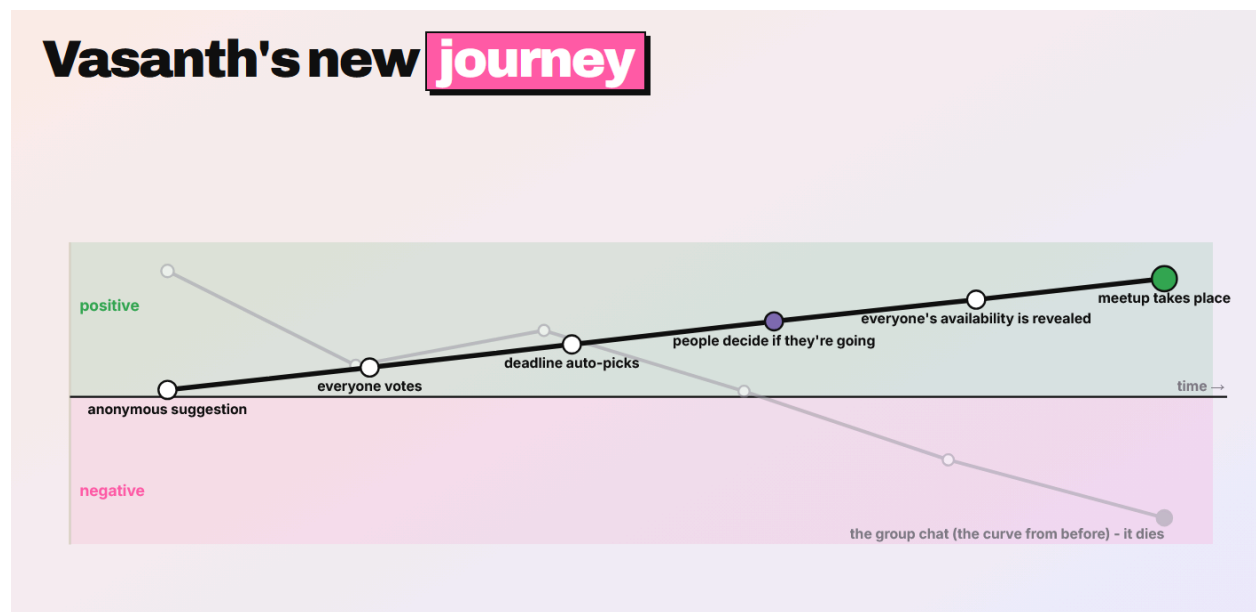
Milly's pub quiz, mapped as she felt it



To determine how meetups are made and how they fall apart, we conducted interviews with undergraduates from different universities. Interviewing a mix of people who typically organise meetups and people who remain passive in the group chat allowed us to gain insights into all angles of the problem landscape, ensuring any solutions we come up with directly benefit everyone.

Someone who typically organises meetups told us:

“I do all the work - where we’re going, who’s paying, making sure everyone’s free - then half of them don’t even reply and it just dies. All that effort for nothing.”



Opportunity Statement

How might we reduce hesitancy in undergraduate friend groups when planning to meet up so that groups go from frustrating 'maybe' responses to a clear consensus?

Testing and Validation

Our Methodology

To ensure our development remained focussed on user needs, we conducted several interviews daily with university students, our target audience. Our approach was generally to let the users explore the app themselves, with minimal guidance at first. This ensured we understood exactly what a new user would encounter and how they would proceed.

26th May 2026	
High School Reunion	
Dinner	La Palombe
GOING	20:00
6th June 2026	
Football Group	
Football	Goals Wembley
NOT GOING	10:00
Suggest a Meet	

Impact